CERNO GLOBUS

FIELD INTELLIGENCE

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Commercial & Facilities

Fire Protection · Paving · Facilities Services · Security Systems · Elevator · Venue & Catering

Six trades, one publication. Every item is something that moves a number on your P&L, changes what you must do by law, or changes what parts and labor cost you.

IN THIS ISSUE

FIRE PROTECTION
NFSA's October 8 high-rise guidance says steel and listed CPVC can be mixed in one sprinkler system, and tells owners to compare total installed cost rather than price per foot.

PAVING
A peer-reviewed study announced October 8 and commissioned by NAPA and other asphalt groups reports emissions from in-place compacted asphalt pavement more than 250 times lower than earlier estimates.

FACILITIES SERVICES
Cintas and UniFirst agreed not to close their $5.5 billion merger before December 11 unless the FTC clears it sooner, after certifying compliance with the FTC's information requests.

SECURITY SYSTEMS
An Interface Systems study reported October 8 prices a false alarm at $150 to $500 in blended fees and puts a 10-store retailer's baseline annual cost at $7,230.

ELEVATOR
California generally requires annual elevator inspections, and Mission Local reported August 27 that more than a third of San Francisco's roughly 2,800 single-elevator buildings have no recorded inspection in over three years.

VENUE & CATERING
Restaurant Dive reported October 5 that restaurants' worst disaster losses come afterward, citing CRS data that 40% of businesses do not reopen and Georgia restaurant sales fell nearly 10% in Hurricane Helene week.

BACKGROUND SIGNAL
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

Read it online
This issue, and every one before it

LABOR

Building service contractors expect wage demands to rise, 72.5% say, and 82.3% expect higher supply and operating costs, while 32% plan robotic floor equipment within 12 months, about double 2025.

A 2026 building service contractor market study by Contracting Profits and BSCAI, summarized by CleanLink on September 28, finds 72.5% of contractors expect wage or salary demands to increase and 69% expect the overall cost of cleaning to rise. The summary gives no sample size.

Another 82.3% expect the cost of supplies and doing business to rise, and 44.6% expect labor challenges to increase in 2026. 38.3% expect more demand for automation or technology in contracts.

About 32% plan to adopt robotic floor equipment within 12 months, roughly double the 2025 share. The payback figures in the same article come from a 2019 AACEM/ISSA survey, in which about 70% of non-adopters expected to recover cost within two years, and they are not a 2026 measurement.

Separately, CleanLink's poll finds 44% say wage competition is a main cause of staffing shortages.

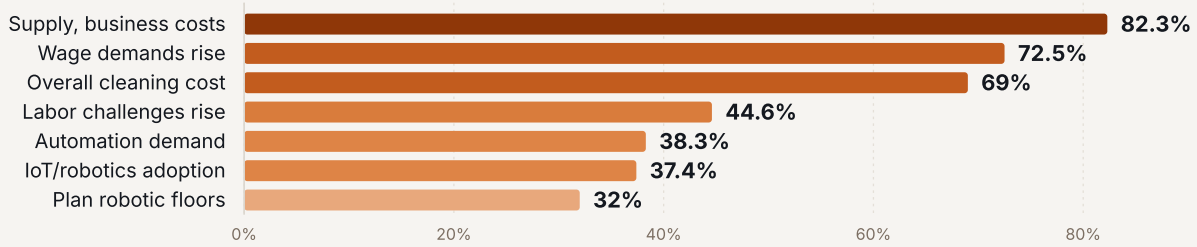
What to do about it: If you buy janitorial service, pull your contract and mark the term end and escalator, then ask now for next year's rate in writing instead of waiting for a notice. If you run a cleaning firm, rebuild next year's bids on a wage increase rather than current payroll, and price in supplies at the higher cost. Before buying a robotic scrubber, time your own crews on the floors it would cover and ask the vendor for measured payback at a customer your size, not a survey average. Keep your lowest pay band under review against local rents.

CleanLink: Factors in Robotic Floor Care Adoption · CleanLink: Cleaners Pay the Cost of Living

INFOGRAPHIC 1 / CLEANING COST OUTLOOK

Four in five building service contractors expect supply and operating costs to rise, and more than seven in ten expect higher wage demands.

Share of building service contractors giving each answer in the 2026 BSC Market Study (Contracting Profits and BSCAI), %, as summarized by CleanLink on September 28, 2026; sample size not stated



Seven in ten expect to pay more for labor and four in five for supplies. If you buy cleaning, expect rate requests at renewal. If you sell it, price wages in now. Only 32% plan robotic floor gear within 12 months, double 2025; the summary gives no sample size and cites 2019 payback data. CleanLink: Factors in Robotic Floor Care Adoption

FIRE PROTECTION

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

NFSA's October 8 high-rise guidance says steel and listed CPVC can be mixed in one sprinkler system, and tells owners to compare total installed cost rather than price per foot.

Why it matters: NFSA (Oct 8) says NFPA 13 allows both steel and listed CPVC, and recommends steel for standpipes, risers and fire pump piping with CPVC on residential floors, joined by listed transition fittings. It lists labor, fabrication, material handling, ceiling and wall access, restoration, occupant coordination and project duration as the costs to compare, and gives no dollar figures. Retrofits should first check existing risers, pumps and water supply for pressure and flow. If you are pricing a high-rise retrofit, ask each bidder for every pipe option as a complete installed scope and get the CPVC listing and pressure limits in writing.

NFSA: High-Rise Sprinkler Systems and CPVC Pipe

REGULATION

NFPA's Standards Council approved renumbering NFPA 13E, the fire department operations guide for sprinklered buildings, as NFPA 1713, but NFSA's September 22 notice gives no effective date.

Why it matters: NFSA (Sept 22) says the change took more than 18 months and moves the document, first issued in 1966, into NFPA's 1700-series of fire service response documents under a different technical committee. It covers pre-incident planning, fire department connections, fire pumps and impairments, and NFSA describes the document as being about fire department use of systems, not how to design them. No new owner obligation is stated. The practical step is housekeeping: search your impairment procedures, inspection report templates and pre-fire plans for "NFPA 13E" and note the new number so references stay current once the renumbering takes effect.

NFSA: Renumbering of NFPA 13E to NFPA 1713

PAVING

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

A peer-reviewed study announced October 8 and commissioned by NAPA and other asphalt groups reports emissions from in-place compacted asphalt pavement more than 250 times lower than earlier estimates.

Why it matters: The UC Riverside study, published in ACS ES&T Air, tested compacted pavement under realistic temperature and sunlight, where earlier work used small uncompacted lab samples. NAPA says it supports treating in-place pavement as not a significant source of smog-forming emissions. The 250-fold figure is NAPA's wording, the release gives no emission rates, and the Asphalt Institute, NAPA, Eurobitume and SAPA commissioned it. NAPA names no rule or permit it changes. If a city, DOT or neighbor challenges a paving or plant project on air-quality grounds, keep the DOI (10.1021/acsestair.6c00071) on file and ask your state paving association how it is being used.

NAPA: Landmark Study on Asphalt Pavement Emissions

SUPPLY

FHWA's 2026 asphalt table puts Baltimore at $597.50 a ton in August, 29.9% above January and 4.0% below its June peak of $622.50, with Northern Virginia at $622.50.

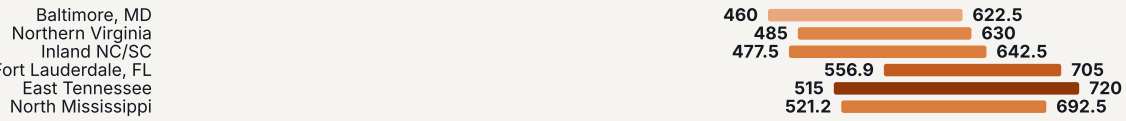
Why it matters: FHWA Federal Lands' monthly averages, filled in through August with September blank, show Baltimore rising from $460.00 in January to $622.50 in June, and Northern Virginia from $485.00 to a $630.00 June peak before easing to $622.50. Inland North and South Carolina stand at $635.00 and East Tennessee at $686.25. Anyone who bid fixed-price work in the first quarter is carrying these increases unless the contract has a price-adjustment clause. Pull each open paving contract, check for an asphalt index clause and which published index it names, and file the adjustment request in writing before the next pay application.

FHWA Federal Lands 2026 asphalt price table

INFOGRAPHIC 2 / ASPHALT JAN TO PEAK

Asphalt rose 27% to 40% from January to its 2026 peak in six Southeast and Mid-Atlantic markets.

Monthly average asphalt price, $ per US ton, January 2026 (low) to highest month January-August 2026 (high); FHWA Federal Lands 2026 asphalt table, filled through August, no release date published



Baltimore went from $460.00 to a $622.50 peak in June, and its August $597.50 is still 29.9% above January. East Tennessee rose 39.8%, the most of these six. Fixed-price bids written in the first quarter are carrying this gap unless the contract has an asphalt index clause. Check each open job. FHWA Federal Lands 2026 asphalt price table

FACILITIES SERVICES

TWO ITEMS

SUPPLY

Cintas and UniFirst agreed not to close their $5.5 billion merger before December 11 unless the FTC clears it sooner, after certifying compliance with the FTC's information requests.

Why it matters: Counselor reported October 7, from an SEC filing, that both companies certified compliance with the FTC's information requests and agreed not to close before December 11, 2026 unless the FTC finishes earlier. The deal, announced March 11, is valued at about $5.5 billion; the FTC has announced no decision and Cintas still expects to close by year-end. If you buy uniforms, mats or restroom supplies from either company, mark the term end, auto-renew window and escalator clause on each contract, and get one written quote from an independent supplier before any renewal that falls before December 11.

Counselor/ASI: Cintas moves closer to UniFirst deal · UniFirst Q3 fiscal 2026 results and merger terms

LABOR

A cleaning-services platform's analysis of 20 U.S. cities, reported September 29, found some cleaners would need more than 100 paid hours a week to afford local housing, with rent over half of full-time pay across all metros.

Why it matters: CleanLink (Sept 29) cites Find My Local Cleaner's analysis of federal and local wage and housing data; only New York is named, with a median cleaner wage of $21.16 an hour, average rent of $3,615 a month and rent equal to 98.6% of full-time median gross pay. CleanLink's own poll finds 44% of respondents say wage competition is a main cause of staffing shortages. The analysis comes from a cleaning-services platform, not a government survey. If your crews work in high-rent metros, compare your lowest pay band with local rents before the next resignation and build the increase into the next bid.

CleanLink: Cleaners Pay the Cost of Living

SECURITY SYSTEMS

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

An Interface Systems study reported October 8 prices a false alarm at $150 to $500 in blended fees and puts a 10-store retailer's baseline annual cost at $7,230.

Why it matters: Interface (reported by SDM, Oct 8) analyzed ordinances and fee schedules in 25 cities and dispatch policies in 23. For a 10-store operator averaging three false alarms a store it counts $1,220 in municipal fines, and $7,230 once guard dispatches, keyholder logistics and lost labor are added. It says 21 of the 23 cities can suspend or revoke police dispatch, and puts worst-case exposure at $37,230 a year if each store has one break-in after losing response. These are one vendor's model figures. Count your own false alarms by site for 12 months, check each city's dispatch-suspension threshold, and ask your monitoring provider how alarms are verified before dispatch.

SDM: Interface Systems report on false-alarm costs

LABOR

ESA's inaugural Industry Performance Index, reported September 28, counts about 141,000 security system services jobs in 2025 at roughly $93,000 in annualized wages, growing 2.00% a year since 2001.

Why it matters: The index, built with Beacon Economics on BLS Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages data, puts employment at about 86,000 in 2001 and 141,000 in 2025, against 0.86% a year for all private employment. Hiring has been stable since 2022. Real wages grew 1.85% a year over 25 years, against 0.99% for private employers overall. The article gives no forecast, margin or pricing data. The $93,000 is an annualized nominal figure for the whole industry, not a technician rate. Use it as a rough check on whether your installer and technician pay, and the labor rate in your bids, is keeping pace.

SDM: ESA Industry Performance Index

ELEVATOR

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

California generally requires annual elevator inspections, and Mission Local reported August 27 that more than a third of San Francisco's roughly 2,800 single-elevator buildings have no recorded inspection in over three years.

Why it matters: Mission Local (reported August 27, updated September 3) counts nearly 1,200 passenger elevators uninspected for over five years. Buildings with a full maintenance contract with a licensed elevator company can qualify for a two-year permit. A supervisor said in late July he is drafting a bill requiring repairs within 24 hours and landlord-paid relocation of seniors, disabled tenants and families with young children when repairs run longer; no fines, hearing or effective dates are published. If you own or service California elevators, confirm every permit expiration and ask your maintenance contractor whether your contract meets the full-maintenance test for the two-year permit.

Mission Local: San Francisco Has an Elevator Problem

MONEY

Maryland's Elevator Safety Review Board, on an undated fee page, lists a two-year elevator mechanic license at $175 initial and $200 renewal, and a contractor license at $275 and $300, each plus a $25 application fee.

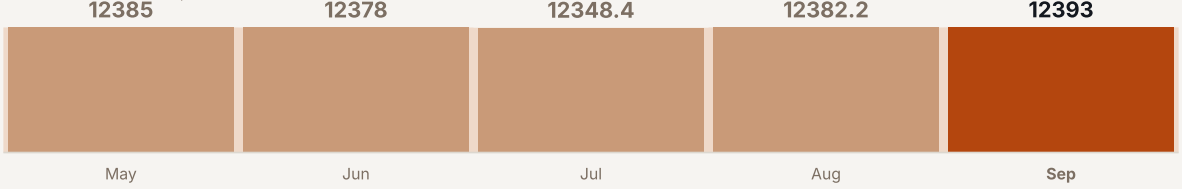
Why it matters: The board's fee page also lists $125 and $150 for an accessibility lift mechanic, a $25 30-day temporary mechanic license with $10 renewals, no fee for 30-day emergency mechanic licenses, and $25 each for reinstatement and license verification. The page carries no effective date and says fees are set by law and regulation and may change with public notice. Maryland contractors should calendar every mechanic's renewal, since reinstatement costs extra, and note that a temporary license lapses after 30 days. Owners hiring a Maryland contractor can ask for current license numbers and verify them with the board.

Maryland Elevator Safety Review Board: Fees

INFOGRAPHIC 3 / FOOD SERVICE JOBS

Food-service employment recovered to 12.393 million in September after a July dip, only 8,000 above May.

BLS All Employees, Food Services and Drinking Places (CES7072200001), thousands of persons, seasonally adjusted, May-Sep 2026; FRED release of Oct 2, 2026 (next release Nov 6)



Food-service payrolls ended September 8,000 above May after a 29,600-job drop in July, so headcount in the sector is roughly flat. If you run a venue or caterer, budget next season's event staffing on today's headcount, not growth, and lock in returning seasonal crews early. FRED/BLS: Food Services and Drinking Places jobs

VENUE & CATERING

TWO ITEMS

INSURANCE

Restaurant Dive reported October 5 that restaurants' worst disaster losses come afterward, citing CRS data that 40% of businesses do not reopen and Georgia restaurant sales fell nearly 10% in Hurricane Helene week.

Why it matters: Brokers quoted say restaurants are often underinsured, that business interruption coverage pays lost income but not on your cash timetable, and that franchisees still owe advertising and royalty fees while closed. Georgia sales fell nearly 10% year over year that week even though fewer than 2% of restaurants closed (Black Box Intelligence). Pull your property and business interruption policy this week and confirm the covered period and whether code upgrades are paid. Ask your broker in writing whether a neighboring tenant's sprinkler discharge or a utility outage is covered, and name your restoration vendors now.

Restaurant Dive: Worst disaster losses come after damage

REGULATION

Maryland's ban on dynamic pricing by food retailers and third-party delivery services, which bars prices set from personal consumer data, took effect October 1.

Why it matters: FOX 5 DC (Sept 30, updated Oct 1) lists the Protection From Predatory Pricing Act among Maryland laws effective October 1. The report describes the ban as covering food retailers and third-party delivery services and does not define either term or state penalties, so it is unclear whether a caterer or restaurant selling directly falls inside it. The statute itself was not retrieved. If you sell through delivery apps in Maryland, ask each platform in writing how it is complying and whether your menu prices are affected. If you take your own online catering orders, hold any pricing that varies by customer data until you have read the statute.

FOX 5 DC: New laws in Maryland, DC and Virginia Oct 1

THE BACKGROUND SIGNAL

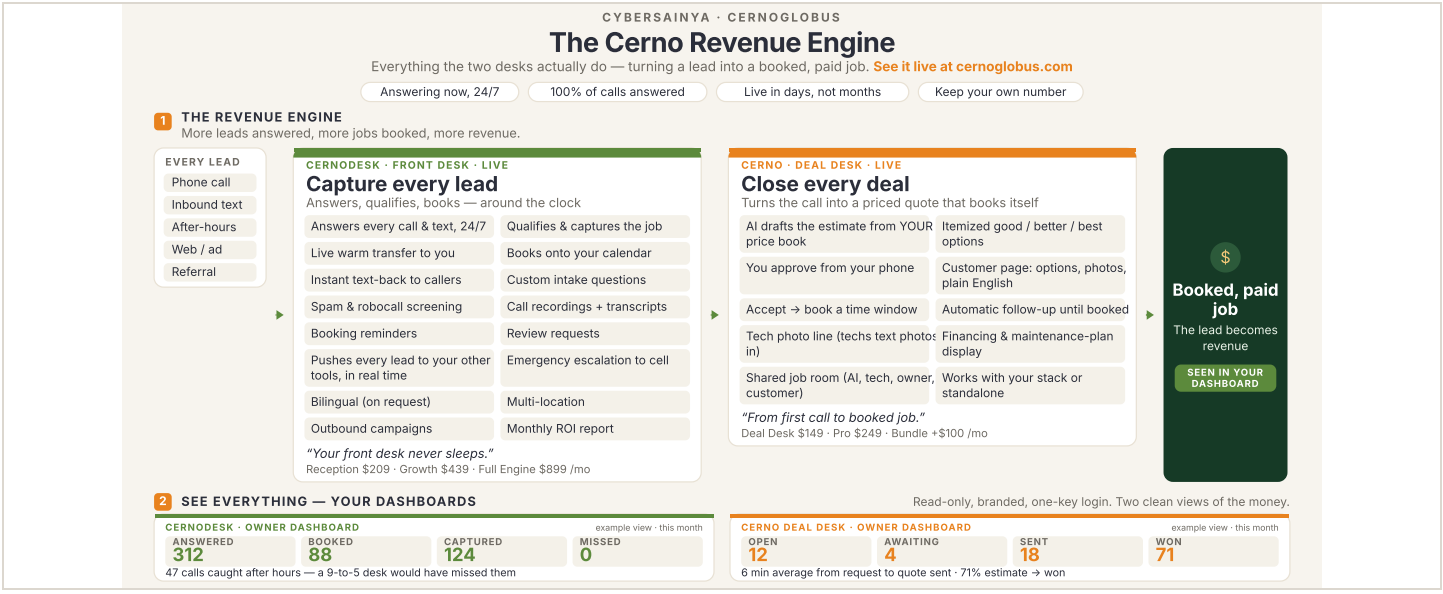
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center took 24,768 business email compromise reports in 2025, with losses of $3.05 billion — a record, after dipping to $2.77 billion in 2024 from $2.95 billion in 2023. Across all internet crime it logged 1,008,597 complaints and $20.88 billion in losses. Reported cases only, so read it as a floor.

Business email compromise, not ransomware, is the one that should concern a commercial contractor. Someone gets into a mailbox, reads until they understand how you invoice and who pays you, then sends a real-looking progress billing with different bank details. No malware, no warning — just a payment that never arrives and an argument about who eats it. A trade that emails proposals, work orders and vendor invoices all day is the shape this is built for. The quieter number is adoption: under 20% of firms with fewer than 20 staff use AI at all.

What to do about it: You don't need a security program. You need multi-factor authentication on email and your accounting login, and one rule everybody follows: nobody changes bank details on the strength of an email or a call — you ring the number you already had on file and confirm. That covers most of it, and costs nothing. The part it doesn't — how the systems are set up — is the day job of our parent company, CyberSainya.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Internet Crime Report — reported cases only, rounded from $2,946,830,270, $2,770,151,146 and $3,046,598,558. U.S. Census Bureau, Business Trends and Outlook Survey, May 3, 2026.



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